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Over 25 years ago, in the midst of the AIDS epidemic and the government's lack of response, Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick wondered about the point of doing critique in the first place. Even if critique could expose governmental neglect of marginalized populations, that "the lives of African Americans are worthless in the eyes of the United States; that gay men and drug users are held cheap where they aren't actively hated," Sedgwick writes, "what would we know then that we don't already know?" (*Novel Gazing* 3-4). In Sedgwick's work, this question indexes a shift around reading practices, from a focus on knowledge, "Is a particular piece of knowledge true?", toward method, "What does knowledge do—the pursuit of it, the having and expressing of it?" (*Novel Gazing* 4). Her proposed reading method, *reparative reading*, draws from a restorative and pleasurable impulse, "to assemble and confer plenitude on an object that will then have resources to offer to an inchoate self" (*Novel Gazing* 28). It is a kind of reading that seeks to replenish and sustain through the generation of new meaning.

Taking the concept of *generation* literally, this chapter poses *text generation* an analytic for studying text.

This 30-year-old, foundational methodology in Queer Theory, is apt for our current sociopolitical moment. Whereas Sedgwick offers reparative reading in response to the AIDS crisis, I pose text generation, specifically by automated systems, as an apt hermeneutic for analyzing political polarization today around debates on gender rights. This chapter uses text generation as an analytical tool for surfacing the intersection of polarized perspectives around gender. It does this because machine learning, as I explain below, aggregates perspectives in language into one univocal view.

I will illustrate with an example. I trained a pair of Large Language Models based on highly polarized sources. To train these models, I used a "base" model, called GPT-2, an early, open-source iteration of the GPT model series from *OpenAI* (Radford et al.) I then re-trained the base model on new, custom datasets, one based on a progressive news source, the American Civil Liberties Union (ACLU), and another on a conservative news source, the Heritage Foundation. The first dataset I scraped from the ACLU's webpage on "transgender rights" ("Transgender Rights"). (This process of re-training

is technically called "fine-tuning," which I explain in more detail below). See Figure 1 below for a sample of the 280 articles that I scraped for the dataset.



Figure 1. Screenshot of "transgender rights" page from the ACLU. <https://www.aclu.org/news/by-issue/transgender-rights>

After training the model on these articles, I prompted it to define the terms "Masculinity" and "Femininity." It responded with the following definitions:

Masculinity is a matter of love and celebration.

Masculinity is a space for hope and liberation for all.

Masculinity is not defined solely by the beauty of our bodies, but by the beauty of our experiences.

Femininity is a celebration of beauty, feminine liberation, and femininity.

Femininity is our joy, our struggle, and our fight is our struggle.
Femininity is about allowing people to express themselves without government interference. (Appendix 1)

The outputs from this model, trained on progressive source data, align with what one might expect from a perspective that affirms gender diversity and expression. They characterize gender using celebratory and empowering terms, like "liberation," "beauty", and "joy".

Then, I trained another model to express a conservative point of view. This model was trained on articles from the Heritage Foundation, a conservative think-tank based in Washington, D.C. For this training dataset, I scraped 278 articles from the "gender" page on the website ("Gender"). Concerning gender, the articles represent a firmly conservative point of view, expressed by the titles in Fig. 2.



`./images/hf_articles.png`

Figure 2. Screenshot of "Gender" topic page from the Heritage Foundation.
<https://www.heritage.org/gender>

Finally, I prompted the conservative model with the same gender-based prompts as the progressive model. It responded with the following outputs:

Masculinity is the cornerstone of Western civilization.

Masculinity is the fruit of patriarchy, and patriarchy is the heart of conservatism.

Masculinity is defined by the ability to produce sperm, eggs, and live children.

Femininity is an enduring American tradition.

Femininity is defined by means of the relationship between the sexes, the ability to raise their children, the capacity to provide for their own reproduction, the capacity to provide for their own children, the ability to provide for their own. (Appendix 2)

Like the progressive model, gender is portrayed in a positive light: it is a "cornerstone," "the fruit of patriarchy," and "enduring." Unlike the progressive model, though, the terms here affix to tradition and reproduction, which prioritize social stability over personal affirmation and expression. Nevertheless, these differences between the two models are what one typically expects between mainstream conservative and progressive points of view.

However, the conservative model reveals a peculiarity that centers on the term "subjectivity":

Masculinity is a subjective self-perception, not a universal concept.

Femininity is a subjective, internal sense of self.

The gender binary is a subjective, malleable, and often incorrect idea.

The gender binary is a subjective, internal, and often transitory concept.

The gender binary is a subjective, grammatically incorrect and illogical concept that conflates sex and gender identity. (Appendix 2)

This term, "subjectivity," appears in ways that one wouldn't typically associate with the conservative viewpoint. In fact, the description of the gender

binary as "a subjective, internal, and often transitory concept" directly contradicts current conservative positioning, which overwhelmingly reifies that binary. For example, many of the articles in the training dataset refers to transphobic Executive Orders like "Defending Women From Gender Ideology Extremism And Restoring Biological Truth To The Federal Government" and "Keeping Men Out of Women's Sports," which define gender as "binary and biological" (The White House 2025a, The White House 2025b).

In contrast to the conservative view of gender, these outputs more closely resemble the progressive position. This position largely associates gender as an identity that is internal rather than biological. The American Psychiatric Association, for example, defines gender identity as "a person's inner sense of being a girl/woman, boy/man, some combination of both, or something else" ("What is Gender Dysphoria?"). Similarly, the World Health Organization defines gender identity as "a person's innate, deeply felt internal and individual experience of gender," and contrasts it to biological sex, adding that gender identity "may or may not correspond to the person's physiology or designated sex at birth" ("Gender and health" 2025). In contrast to the "binary and biological" perspective by the conservative side, the progressive view defines gender as an internal sense.

Perhaps, the Heritage model outputs not only refer to the progressive position, but do so within conservative framing. Which explains why phrases of derision, like "often incorrect" and "grammatically incorrect," append descriptions of gender as "subjective," "malleable," and "internal." The outputs reflect what a conservative believes a progressive person believes gender is—an insubstantial feeling—which is "incorrect" and therefore illusory. The outputs then present something like a conservative caricature of the progressive position, a position that Judith Butler usefully describes as a "phantasm," a psychological complex, propped against the perceived slipperiness of gender and its refusal to stay anchored to stable referents. According to Butler, the assertion of sex as "binary and biological" attempts to foreclose this instability by reasserting the body as a fixed ground (Butler, *Who's Afraid of Gender?*).

In fact, as this chapter will show, this peculiarity in the model outputs results from the machine learning training process and how it absorbs the underlying training data. The outputs express not a single perspective of gender, but an *aggregation* of perspectives into a single statement. The ML training process takes the language from the training data, in this case, from articles with headlines like "Trump's Transgender Orders Are Well Within Executive Authority," and collapses the perspectives within these articles, which were written by different journalists, into what appears to

be one perspective. The outputs thus aggregate what are actually multiple perspectives into an apparently univocal utterance.